

LUBEO TECH SOLUTIONS

Digital Strategy & Technology Services

DIGITAL STRATEGY & WEBSITE UPGRADE PROPOSAL

Prepared for

The South African Union of Students (SAUS)

Prepared by

Lubeo Tech Solutions

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1. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The South African Union of Students (SAUS) is the official representative body for Student Representative Councils (SRCs) across all South African public universities. Founded in 2006 at Stellenbosch University, SAUS plays a critical role in higher education governance and student advocacy at a national level.

Following our initial engagement, the Lubeo Tech Solutions team has conducted a thorough audit of SAUS's current digital presence, including the website (www.saus.org.za), social media channels, and email systems. This report presents our findings, identifies key issues, and outlines a comprehensive strategy to elevate SAUS's digital presence to match the organisation's significance and authority.

Our core findings are as follows:

- The current website has significant design, content, and technical issues that undermine credibility
- Social media presence is fragmented and underutilised across all platforms
- Email infrastructure needs to be properly configured and professionalised
- There is enormous untapped potential to grow SAUS's visibility and influence through strategic digital engagement

This proposal outlines how Lubeo Tech Solutions will address each of these areas, the delivery timeline, and our ongoing management approach.

2. CURRENT STATE ASSESSMENT

2.1 Website Audit (www.saus.org.za)

The current website is built on WordPress and appears to have been recently set up (likely September 2025, based on content dates). While it has a basic structure, several critical issues need to be addressed.

Technical & Design Issues Identified

Issue	Severity	Details
Team section duplicated	High	The About Us page shows the President's card repeated 12 times instead of showing the full leadership team (6 members)
Placeholder content visible	High	The timeline section contains a generic 'Some information' placeholder text that was never replaced
Broken navigation links	Medium	Multiple 'Find Out More' and CTA buttons link to '#' (nowhere)
Inconsistent branding	Medium	No consistent colour scheme, typography, or visual identity across pages
No mobile optimisation	Medium	Site layout is not fully responsive for mobile users
Missing SEO fundamentals	Medium	No meta descriptions, no structured data, poor heading hierarchy
Cookie consent plugin	Low	Cookie banner is configured but empty (no actual cookies categorised)
Testimonial is generic	Medium	'Sarah Johnson – Student Leader' appears to be placeholder, not an actual SAUS member
Events not functional	High	Events section shows static text with no actual event management or calendar
No member/SRC portal	Medium	No way for SRC members to access resources, documents, or updates

Content & Structure Issues

- The homepage is too long and repetitive; the same mission information appears multiple times
- No 'Resources' or 'Documents' section for policy papers, statements, or the SAUS constitution
- The 'Gallery' and 'Media' pages are separate but serve overlapping purposes
- No blog or regular content strategy beyond press statements
- The website was built by 'Zapture' (visible in footer) and appears to have been a quick setup

What Is Working

- The domain name (saus.org.za) is professional and appropriate
- WordPress is a solid platform choice and can be upgraded
- Recent press statements show the organisation is actively producing content
- SSL/HTTPS is already active
- Core page structure (Home, About, News, Events, Gallery, Contact) is logical

2.2 Social Media Audit

SAUS has a presence on several social media platforms, but engagement and consistency are significantly lacking.

Platform	Handle / URL	Status & Issues
Facebook	@SAUStudents	Active, but limited recent engagement. Most active platform.
X (Twitter)	@SAUS_2019	Dormant — zero visible posts despite account existing since 2019.
Instagram	@sa.union.of.students	Account exists but very limited activity and followers.
LinkedIn	South African Union of Students	~95 followers. Good bio but no regular content.
YouTube	Listed on website	Link on website is not connected to an actual channel.
TikTok	Listed on website	Link on website is not connected to an actual TikTok account.

Key Observations:

- There is no unified content calendar or posting strategy across platforms
- The website lists YouTube and TikTok links that do not actually go anywhere
- The Twitter/X account has zero visible posts despite being created in 2019
- There is no WhatsApp channel or Telegram group, which are highly popular among SA students
- Visual branding (profile pictures, banners, post templates) is inconsistent across platforms

2.3 Email & Communication Systems

SAUS currently uses domain-based email (Secretariat@saus.org.za and info@saus.org.za). The reported email problems are likely related to one or more of the following:

- DNS records (MX, SPF, DKIM, DMARC) may not be correctly configured, causing delivery failures
- The email hosting may be tied to the web hosting package, which often has limited storage and reliability
- No professional email management system (such as Google Workspace or Microsoft 365) is in place

- Emails may be going to spam due to missing authentication records
- There may be no backup or archiving system for official correspondence

A proper email audit will require access to the domain's DNS settings and current hosting control panel, which will be conducted in Phase 1 of the project.

3. RECOMMENDED SOLUTIONS

3.1 Website Redesign & Upgrade

Rather than building a completely new website from scratch, Lubeo Tech Solutions recommends a strategic redesign of the existing content — one that is modern, authoritative, and fit for a national student body. This approach preserves domain authority, reduces costs, and delivers a dramatically improved result.

Proposed Website Structure

Page	Purpose	Key Features
Home	First impression & hub	Hero banner, latest news ticker, quick links, upcoming events
About SAUS	Organisation overview	History, mission/vision, constitution (PDF download), partner logos
Leadership	Team profiles	President, Deputy, SG, and all NEC members with photos and bios
News & Statements	Press releases	Blog-style news with categories, search, and share buttons
Events	Event management	Calendar view, event registration, past event gallery
Resources	Document repository	Policy documents, reports, research papers, SRC toolkits
SRC Portal	Member area	Password-protected area for SRC-specific resources and updates
Media Gallery	Photos & videos	Organised albums from congresses, campaigns, and events
Contact	Enquiries	Contact form, office details, map, social media links

Design Principles

- Mobile-first responsive design: the majority of SA students access the web via mobile devices
- Clean, modern, and authoritative visual identity befitting a national student body
- Fast loading speeds: optimised images, caching, and CDN implementation
- Accessibility compliant: ensuring the site is usable by students with disabilities
- SEO optimised: proper meta tags, structured data, sitemap, and content strategy
- Consistent branding with SAUS colours, logo, and typography across all pages

3.2 Email System Resolution

Lubeo Tech Solutions recommends migrating SAUS email to Google Workspace, which provides:

- Professional @saus.org.za email addresses with 30GB storage per user
- Reliable delivery with built-in spam protection
- Proper SPF, DKIM, and DMARC authentication to prevent emails going to spam
- Google Drive for shared document storage and collaboration
- Google Calendar for event coordination across the NEC
- Admin console for managing users, permissions, and security

Alternatively, Microsoft 365 can be considered if the team prefers Outlook. Preference will be assessed during onboarding.

Immediate email fixes we will implement:

- Audit and correct DNS records (MX, SPF, DKIM, DMARC)
- Set up proper email accounts for all NEC members (president@saus.org.za, sg@saus.org.za, etc.)
- Configure email forwarding and shared inboxes where needed
- Set up email signatures with SAUS branding for all members
- Implement email backup and archiving procedures

3.3 Social Media Strategy

SAUS's social media needs a complete strategic overhaul. Students live on social media, and this is where SAUS must meet them.

Platform Prioritisation

Priority	Platform	Strategy
Primary	X (Twitter)	Breaking news, statements, live event coverage, engagement with media and government
Primary	Instagram	Visual storytelling: event photos, reels, infographics, student spotlights
Primary	TikTok	Short-form video: explainers on student rights, NSFAS updates, behind-the-scenes
Secondary	Facebook	Community building, event pages, longer-form content and discussions
Secondary	LinkedIn	Professional engagement with higher education stakeholders and government
Secondary	WhatsApp Channel	Direct updates to students — most-used messaging app in SA
Future	YouTube	Long-form content: press conferences, panel discussions, documentary-style content

Content Pillars

- Official Statements & News: press releases, responses to policy changes, government engagement
- Student Rights & Education: explainers on NSFAS, accommodation rights, academic exclusion, and mental health
- Campus Spotlight: feature stories from different university SRCs across the country
- Events & Campaigns: coverage of congresses, workshops, and national campaigns
- Leadership & Accountability: updates from the NEC, transparency posts, Q&A sessions
- Student Voice: polls, questions, and user-generated content from students nationwide

Implementation Actions

- Create and verify all social media accounts with consistent branding (profile photos, banners, bios)
- Design branded post templates for statements, events, quotes, and infographics
- Develop a monthly content calendar with at least 3–4 posts per week across primary platforms
- Set up social media management tools (Buffer or Hootsuite) for scheduled posting
- Train a SAUS media officer or volunteer team on content creation and social media management
- Establish a response protocol for engaging with trending student issues on social media

3.4 Brand Visibility & Growth Strategy

Beyond fixing immediate digital issues, SAUS needs a broader strategy to become a recognisable and authoritative voice in South African higher education.

Recommendations for Growth

Media Engagement: Build relationships with education journalists at major outlets (Daily Maverick, News24, SABC, eNCA). Issue regular, well-formatted press releases.

Google Presence: Set up and optimise a Google Business Profile for SAUS. Implement a content/SEO strategy so SAUS appears in search results for queries like 'student union South Africa'.

Newsletter: Launch a monthly email newsletter to SRC leaders, university administrators, media, and students to position SAUS as a thought leader.

Partnerships & Sponsorships: Approach organisations in the education and youth development space — NYDA, Harambee, Allan Grey Orbis Foundation, and university alumni associations.

Annual Report: Publish a professional annual report documenting SAUS activities, achievements, financial transparency, and goals.

Campus Ambassador Programme: Establish a network of SAUS ambassadors at every university who can share content, gather student feedback, and represent SAUS locally.

Podcast or Live Series: Launch a regular podcast or live stream series discussing student issues, interviewing SRC leaders, and debating higher education policy.

4. IMPLEMENTATION ROADMAP

The project will be delivered in four phases over approximately 12 weeks. Phases overlap intentionally to ensure efficient delivery. Email issues will be prioritised and addressed immediately in Phase 1.

Phase	Timeline	Deliverables
Phase 1: Audit & Setup	Weeks 1–2	Full technical audit of website, email, and hosting. DNS and email fixes. Access handover and platform setup.
Phase 2: Website Redesign	Weeks 3–6	New design mockups, content restructuring, development, testing, and launch of redesigned website.
Phase 3: Social Media Activation	Weeks 4–8	Account setup/verification, branded templates, content calendar, initial content push, team training.
Phase 4: Growth & Handover	Weeks 9–12	Newsletter setup, SEO implementation, Google Business Profile, ambassador programme framework, documentation and training.

5. SERVICE MANAGEMENT APPROACH

Lubeo Tech Solutions will serve as SAUS's ongoing digital services provider. Here is how we will manage the relationship:

During the Project (Weeks 1–12)

- Weekly progress reports sent to the SAUS Secretary General or designated contact
- Fortnightly check-in meetings (virtual) with the NEC or designated committee
- A shared project board (Trello or Notion) for real-time visibility on tasks and milestones
- All content and design decisions will be approved by SAUS before implementation

Ongoing Management (Post-Launch)

- Monthly website maintenance: security updates, plugin updates, backups, performance monitoring
- Monthly social media management support: content calendar creation, template design, analytics reporting
- Email account administration: adding/removing users, resolving delivery issues, and storage management
- Quarterly digital performance reports with analytics and recommendations
- On-demand technical support for urgent issues (24-hour response time)
- Training for new NEC members during each annual leadership transition

6. INVESTMENT OVERVIEW

The following is a high-level cost framework. A detailed quotation with line items will be provided upon approval to proceed. All prices are exclusive of VAT. Domain renewal and hosting fees are separate and will be assessed during the audit.

Service	Type	Estimated Range (ZAR)
Website Redesign & Development	Once-off	R50,000 – R80,000
Email Migration & Setup (Google Workspace)	Once-off setup + monthly	R6,000 setup + ~R198/user/month
Social Media Setup & Branding Pack	Once-off	R10,000 – R16,000
Content Calendar & Training	Once-off	R6,000 – R10,000
Monthly Website Maintenance	Monthly retainer	R3,000 – R6,000/month
Monthly Social Media Management Support	Monthly retainer	R6,000 – R12,000/month
SEO & Google Business Setup	Once-off	R4,000 – R8,000
Newsletter Setup (Mailchimp/Brevo)	Once-off	R4,000 – R6,000
Bulk SMS	Once-off	R8,000 – R12,000
ALL SERVICES ABOVE (Complete Package)	Monthly retainer	R50,000/month

Where SAUS has budget constraints, Lubeo Tech Solutions is open to discussing phased payments or prioritisation of critical items first. We are committed to finding a sustainable working arrangement that serves SAUS's needs.

7. WHY LUBEO TECH SOLUTIONS

Lubeo Tech Solutions is a South African technology and digital strategy firm dedicated to empowering organisations, businesses, and youth-serving institutions through smart, practical digital solutions. Here is why we are the right partner for SAUS:

- Proven experience in web development, digital strategy, and IT services for organisations and businesses across South Africa
- Deep understanding of the local digital landscape and the student ecosystem, including platform behaviour, connectivity constraints, and content preferences
- Hands-on approach: we do not outsource. You work directly with our lead developer and strategist throughout the project
- Expertise in training and capacity building, ensuring SAUS's team can independently manage day-to-day digital tasks after handover
- Flexible, responsive, and committed to long-term partnership rather than one-off project delivery
- Dedicated to using technology to empower organisations that serve young people and education in South Africa
- Full-service capability: from infrastructure and email systems to design, content strategy, and social media management — all under one roof

Our Commitment

We understand that SAUS is not just a client — it is a national institution representing hundreds of thousands of students. We take that responsibility seriously. Our goal is to help SAUS build a digital presence that reflects its authority, reaches students where they are, and sustains itself long after our initial engagement ends.

8. NEXT STEPS

To move forward, we propose the following immediate actions:

1. Review this proposal and provide feedback or questions to Lubeo Tech Solutions
 2. Schedule an introductory meeting with the NEC or designated digital committee
 3. Grant Lubeo Tech Solutions access to the current hosting, domain, and email administration panels
 4. Approve Phase 1 to begin the technical audit and immediate email fixes
 5. Lubeo Tech Solutions to deliver a detailed quotation and project plan
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We look forward to partnering with SAUS to build a digital presence that truly reflects the importance and impact of the South African Union of Students.

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